



**STATEMENT DELIVERED BY ALICIA BÁRCENA IBARRA, MEXICO'S
SECRETARY OF FOREIGN AFFAIRS, DURING THE GENERAL DEBATE OF
THE 78TH SESSION OF THE UNITED NATIONS GENERAL ASSEMBLY**

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Mr. President, Dennis Francis, my friend,

On behalf of Mexico, please accept our brotherly congratulations on your election to this position. Latin America and the Caribbean feel fully represented under your presidency, a testament to our region's commitment to the purposes of this wonderful Organization.

Mr. President, Heads of State and Government, fellow Ministers, excellences:

Today, the United Nations faces an immense challenge in fulfilling the essence of its mandate: to preserve humanity from the scourge of war, promote and protect all human rights, uphold the rule of international law, and advance the well-being of people with environmental sustainability.

I am deeply honored to be back at the UN headquarters; an organization I proudly served for decades, this time representing the Government of my country: Mexico. What an honor! A nation that is currently undergoing profound and progressive transformations. I am privileged to carry its voice and represent Mexico on the world stage. Please accept the greetings from President Andrés Manuel López Obrador.

Our nations are facing serious threats to international peace and security: we have more than 50 armed conflicts and the proliferation of nuclear weapons; the worsening of a multitude of crises, from humanitarian to climate-related; forced migration of millions of people; the highest increase in inequality and poverty, with 165 million people becoming impoverished in just three years, the challenge of healthcare, the risk of new pandemics, all in a context where there are growing questions about the relevance of multilateralism and its institutions.

However, there is no doubt that our international action loses legitimacy when our resolutions do not translate into concrete benefits for people, the planet, and prosperity.

As highlighted by Secretary-General António Guterres, the 2030 Agenda requires urgent action to “rescue it”. The pandemic hindered progress towards achieving the Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs), but the trajectory before the pandemic was not encouraging, and the current context of macroeconomic and geopolitical uncertainty demands ambitious and immediate measures.

The stagnation in achieving the SDGs is not an abstract metric. We are talking about hundreds of millions of people living in poverty, children facing food insecurity, and an environmental crisis.

The future of people and the planet is not dependent on the hands of fate; it depends on the political decisions and actions we take, guided by the 2030 Agenda. In this context, inequality is the major challenge, because it is not enough to reduce poverty; we need a paradigm shift in development that redistributes power and wealth and closes the unacceptable gaps and asymmetries between the rich and the poor, and among countries.

Equality is not simply about the ownership of rights; inequality is inefficient from an economic perspective, and therefore it is necessary to “Equalize to Grow and Grow to Equalize”. Because we are no longer in an “era of changes”; we are in a “change of era”, and this requires rethinking development and placing equality at the heart of our work.

At the national and international levels, achieving the SDGs depends on a vision of social justice and solidarity, which includes mobilizing the necessary financial resources and the urgent reform of the international financial system.

In the face of this complex backdrop, Mexico will continue to draw strength and inspiration for its international action based on the purposes and

principles of the United Nations Charter, because international cooperation has been channeled through the institutional framework that we have built for almost 80 years.

Mexico has led and will continue proposing any initiative aimed at improving the lives of present and future generations, advocating for genuine and lasting peace and security; equal, resilient, and inclusive sustainable development, with full and unrestricted respect for human rights.

The desire for transformation and the work of our government has focused precisely on transforming the development model to build more and better public goods, guaranteeing rights with fiscal responsibility, based on a fundamental premise: For the good of all, the poor come first.

Our government has underscored the urgency of restoring the role of the state to regulate the relationships between the market, the state, and society; and to implement transformative structural policies.

It is about restoring hope to our people, the hope for a fairer, more equal country, where no one is left behind and no one is excluded. In this regard, over the past few years, we have succeeded in lifting 5 million people out of poverty. We have experienced the largest increase in our minimum wage in history and have established a comprehensive network of social programs that extend rights to the entire population. Nevertheless, we aspire to a vision of equality among all nations, where gaps and asymmetries between countries are closed. We are committed to eliminating the culture of privileges that deny rights.

Mexico reiterates the importance of environmental sustainability as a strategic part of development and not as an externality, emphasizing the relevance of transitioning towards green and blue industrial and productive policies that create employment while reducing the environmental footprint. These policies should also incorporate the contribution and complexity of ecosystems and their services to the economy and well-being.

We vigorously implement the Escazú Agreement and defend environmental defenders, those who give their lives for life. We have also signed the Agreement on the Sustainable Use of Marine Biodiversity, known as BBNJ, and we hope it will come into force soon.

Dear friends:

As Nicholas Stern clearly stated, climate change is the greatest market failure of all time, and today it stands as one of the greatest global risks. Estimates of the costs stemming from its effects demonstrate that it will not only impact economic growth but also the most vulnerable sectors. We reaffirm our commitment to advancing with the Paris Agreement but emphasize the importance of financing to address climate change and give priority to adaptation, especially to support the most vulnerable nations, with the Caribbean being at the forefront in our region.

Alongside this General Assembly, Mexico has participated and continues to participate in the Summit on the SDGs, the Dialogue on Financing for Development, the Climate Ambition Summit, and the upcoming Summit of the Future. We advocate for a profound reform of the international financial architecture that addresses the deep asymmetries between countries, prioritizing heavily indebted countries with new instruments, redistributing special drawing rights to expand the fiscal space of developing countries, or offering debt-for-environment swaps. We also support the Bridgetown Initiative (BA 2.0) proposed by Barbados.

Latin America and the Caribbean learned a very harsh lesson during the pandemic due to the lack of global solidarity. The pressing urgency we face today is to promote, within the Community of Latin American and Caribbean States (CELAC), initiatives such as the Plan for self-sufficiency in health, the Medicines and Medical Devices Regulatory Agency (AMLAC), and the Climate Adaptation Fund. In this regard, we support our dear Ralph Gonsalves González as President of CELAC.

Mexico promotes agreements on all issues across the entire multilateral agenda because we are interested in bridging positions without the exclusion of anyone. However, we are living in unprecedented times that require the joining of more wills to give a voice to all the peoples of the Global South, to which Mexico belongs by history and conviction. Therefore, Mexico is considering taking part in the discussions and efforts of the Group of 77 and China, especially in those issues and forums where we can contribute to strengthening the negotiating position of the Global South. In this regard, we will soon submit a proposal to the Group of 77 and China for their consideration.

A World of Peace

I want to reaffirm Mexico's historical commitment to prioritizing dialogue, mutual understanding in favor of peace, and the peaceful resolution of disputes. This commitment is nourished by our deepest convictions for the determined defense of the best causes of humanity. In our region, we participate as a guarantor country in the Peace Dialogue Table between the Government of the Republic of Colombia and the National Liberation Army (ELN).

Furthermore, Mexico is engaged in the search for solutions for political dialogue in Venezuela, always adhering to our constitutional principles: respecting the self-determination of peoples, non-intervention, and the peaceful resolution of disputes. Mexico hosts negotiations between the Venezuelan government and the Unitary Platform of Venezuela, facilitated by Norway.

We support the implementation of the agreements signed in November 2022 in Mexico City and keep the doors open to resume this process and achieve a solution for the benefit of the entire Venezuelan people.

Turning to the conflict between Russia and Ukraine, our position is unequivocal: we condemn Russia's invasion of Ukraine because it is a violation



of the United Nations Charter and international law, causing unspeakable suffering to millions of people, especially girls and boys.

We recognize that every sovereign state has the right to have the necessary means to regain its territorial integrity, but it is equally true that the arms race takes us further away from a peaceful solution every day. We must stop talking about war and start talking about peace.

Mexico will continue its efforts in favor of disarmament and non-proliferation of nuclear weapons, as evidenced by the Treaty of Tlatelolco and the Treaty on the Prohibition of Nuclear Weapons (TPNW), which are essential for preventing and eradicating the catastrophic humanitarian consequences of nuclear weapons. We have declared in the General Assembly that nuclear weapons represent a great threat and are contrary to international law.

We strongly reject the illicit trafficking of firearms. Just to give you some numbers, 200,000 firearms are trafficked into Mexico from our northern neighbor each year, which, by the way, end up in the hands of organized crime, resulting in countless fatal victims. This is the other side of the coin when it comes to drugs.

Mexico takes its commitment to combating drug trafficking in good faith. However, all efforts will be limited if the countries of manufacture and origin of trafficked arms do not assume their responsibility in addressing this scourge. We need strong measures to reduce the wide availability of firearms. Companies, manufacturers, and distributors must take responsibility and adopt diligent measures to prevent these weapons from being diverted to the illicit market.

In Latin America and the Caribbean, our region, we are devastated by the situation in Haiti, a country that is drowning in the violence of criminal gangs, which largely thrive due to the illicit trafficking of arms, despite the sanctions established by a Security resolution facilitated by Mexico. We hope that the

Security Council will soon approve a new resolution so that the international community can act decisively and support this country in regaining its stability.

We take this opportunity to reaffirm Mexico's commitment to the two-state solution, Israel and Palestine, living side by side in peace within secure borders. We recognize the rights of the Israeli people, but not at the expense of the Palestinian people.

Let us put an end to aberrant situations like the ongoing economic embargo suffered by Cuba, which is entirely unjustified, contrary to international law, and incompatible with the values and peaceful coexistence of the peoples of Latin America and the Caribbean. We demand that Cuba cease to be considered a country that sponsors or encourages terrorism.

Sixty-four years ago, this General Assembly was presided over by one of Mexico's finest diplomats, Luis Padilla Nervo, who said, and I quote *"Victory will not be decided on the battlefield but in the consciences of men and women. Due to the nature of this struggle, the best weapons of democracies are moral principles, scrupulous respect for treaties, and the principle that the difficulties and disputes between countries should not be resolved by arms but through negotiation"*.

Mexico aspires to be an actor that promotes peace through law. Because Mexico's foreign policy is based on the renunciation of war as an instrument of international policy, we will do everything in our power to support genuine efforts for dialogue between parties in conflict and to lead to a peaceful solution. As our renowned diplomat Genaro Estrada once wisely stated, "Foreign policy is based on the renunciation of war."

That is why in this Chamber's entrance, right when you enter this Assembly, you will find an obsidian slab: a sacred stone that the Aztecs called "Itztli", convinced that its origin was the imprint of lightning striking the rocks of the volcanoes, a synthesis of the celestial and the earthly. This piece includes an engraved plaque that defines the foundation of our diplomacy and that was

said 156 years ago by the first indigenous president of Latin America, Benito Juárez: Among individuals, as among nations, respect for the rights of others is peace.

With this humanistic vision, Mexico faces the great challenge of human mobility. Geography has placed us in a very complex position, but Mexico has a very clear compass: to humanize migration. Because migration should be a choice and not an obligation. When a person migrates, they should do so safely, orderly, and regularly. The unprecedented phenomenon of migration concerns the entire international community, all of us together.

That is why Mexico insists on the urgency of addressing the deep-seated structural causes of migration. We reaffirm the importance of supporting the communities of origin and bringing together the will and resources to achieve this.

It requires the support and contribution of all countries, especially recipient countries that benefit from the work and contributions of migrants. Here in the United States, for example, our migrants contribute over 500 billion dollars in taxes.

It is essential, then, to evolve towards migration management models that provide safe and formal spaces for labor and financial integration, facilitating the integration into host societies. Models that protect the human rights of migrants throughout the migration cycle because, as the Secretary-General rightly pointed out, 75 years after the adoption of the Universal Declaration of Human Rights, the time has come to put an end to the persecution and demonization of migrants.

We do not accept, by the way, the questioning of the progressive nature of international standards on gender equality and respect for sexual diversity, which we have worked so hard to build. We advocate for progress in gender equality, avoiding setbacks through decisive and innovative actions: nothing about us (women), nothing without us (women).

Mexico was the first Southern country to proclaim a Feminist Foreign Policy because we are committed to changing the structures that hinder women's progress and the full enjoyment of their rights and autonomy. This implies promoting the substantive participation of women in decision-making and the mainstreaming of gender perspectives in all spaces, forums, international organizations, and agreements, because every time we shatter the glass ceiling, we achieve a breakthrough in civilization.

The theme of this 78th General Assembly is pertinent and precise: rebuilding trust and reactivating global solidarity and this should be the focus of our collective endeavors.

The majestic space in which we are gathered should not allow us to forget the crisis of trust facing international institutions, especially the United Nations. Our deliberations must reflect concrete results, and that is of paramount importance because we must involve the citizens we represent as active participants.

We must be very attentive because multilateralism cannot be lost, and it cannot lose its course amidst polarization and geopolitical rivalries. If the United Nations does not fulfill its mandate of peace and development, we will nurture dissatisfaction and confusion, and the international institutions we have built will suffer.

We are championing a multilateralism that is close to the people, timely and effective, and dedicated to providing global public goods. We believe in the collective, in what belongs to all.

Multilateralism is a tool for development, and the work of the United Nations should create a just peace, expand freedoms, build equality, and deepen democracy. In conclusion, it must create hope.

Political commitment is key to transitioning to a new multilateralism that allows us to restructure international economic and social power relations,

where development topics are given space, in contrast to the excessive and exclusive emphasis on mercantilist neoliberalism.

We hope that this same vision prevails among nations to achieve a fairer world, where precisely, asymmetries are reduced.

We propose a multilateralism that is closer to the needs of the people; consistent with the principles and purposes of the United Nations, strong, timely, and effective.

Because, dear friends, the challenges we face are enormous. On the table is nothing less than uncertainty about our survival. There is no time for gradual modesty, which sometimes is only an excuse to maintain the status quo. The current model of global development is unsustainable. The promise of inevitable and limitless progress has collided with the immovable wall of nature. The year 2030 is just around the corner, and the essential minimums we agreed upon in 2015 are stalled.

That is why we must be inspired by rebellion and a sense of urgency. It is up to this generation and its leaders that the irrevocable responsibility falls to prevent the disaster that science has described to us. This will not be achieved with small steps. It will not be with the meager timidity that discreetly tries not to inconvenience the structural powers that have brought us to this point. It will be with bold and courageous leaps. It will be with the courage to say and do for an equal and just world, where rights are not commodities and nature is not the inevitable victim of our production and consumption patterns.

The obscene concentration of wealth and its corrosive influence on the distribution of power is not compatible with the human project.

Because 78 years ago, we gave shape to this institution, terrified at the precipice when we contemplated the possibility of all of us succumbing to the flames of war.

Today, the precipice draws near, intimidating and real, perhaps even fiercer. That is why our efforts must rise to the occasion.

Dear friends:

In the mid-20th century, this organization was only taking its first steps, and the devastating traces of the last World War were still very fresh. A young Mexican diplomat was scribbling the paragraphs of the fundamental essay about the traits of the identity of my homeland. Those pages would be titled "The Labyrinth of Solitude". Its author, Octavio Paz, would later win the Nobel Prize in recognition of his universal work.

I want to conclude this statement by quoting his lines from that moment:

"We console ourselves by saying that everything has happened as it should not have happened. But it is we who are mistaken, not history. We must learn to look reality in the face; if necessary, we must invent new words and new ideas for these new realities that are challenging us (...) The past has left us orphans, as it has the rest of the planet, and we must join together in inventing our common future. World history has become everyone's task, and our own labyrinth is the labyrinth of all mankind."

And for this task: ensuring new generations a possible world and life, to exit this labyrinth together, count today and always on the fraternal and committed will of Mexico.

Thank you.